Residential Communities Working Group

House Communities Report

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Methodology

What methods did the subgroup use?

- **Interviews:** We conducted 16 students, 1 Program Administrator and 1 Assistant Director interviews. These interviews were semi-structured, with some prepared questions to prompt interviewees to talk about a certain topic, but asking follow up questions as required to gain deeper insights.
- **Observations:** We observed various physical spaces at Stiles and Saybrook residential colleges at Yale. Rohan is a UGA and he had observations from House events and UGA meetings, which are not documented, but contributed to our recommendations.
- **Documents Review:** We reviewed various documents about Dartmouth's House communities, but also the residential colleges model itself. This review occurred in 25F and the documents reviewed are in the House sub-committee folder.

Detailed Research & Synthesis Process could be found in Appendix C.

Key Findings *House Community*

Theme 1: Within the Dartmouth community, students derive a stronger sense of identity from their extracurricular activities (student organizations, clubs, Greek affiliations) than from their house communities.

In our interviews, students commonly reported feeling defined by their campus involvements: “[What groups someone is in] the first thing I ask someone when I meet them”. Students feel a stronger affiliation to groups in which they choose to involve themselves, rather than housing communities, which are assigned randomly and are compulsory for each student. Because of this distinction, we found that only a few students strongly identified with and took pride in their house.

- Key Quotes: *"There is no deeper meaning to being east wheelock. What does it mean to be in East Wheelock?", "House communities feel like they don't exist."*

Theme 2: House communities are most beneficial socially and academically for first year students, especially during their freshman fall.

Houses act as an introductory social setting for new students, allowing freshmen to meet other people. One student reported, "East Wheelock offered me friends when I didn't know anyone." However, as students naturally integrate themselves into student organizations and clubs, or as other cross-house social groups form, students no longer prioritize their involvement within their house communities.

- Key Quotes: *"Once I found people and social places, I didn't feel like engaging in my house anymore.", "House communities were great for making immediate friends."*

Theme 3: Students feel closer to the people in their building community or on their floor than to their larger house community.

The proximity to their peers and the natural day-to-day interaction that occurs on a shared floor or building helps to foster connections and relationships. House communities that consist of many buildings spread across campus tend to suffer further from this disjoint sense of belonging.

- Key Quotes: *"The only way I have interacted with my house is that I live there.", "I was closer to people living in River compared to people in Fahey or Butterfield." – student lived at River*

Theme 4: Students enjoy house merch for free clothing, but do not wear or seek out the items to signify their connection to their house community.

- Key Quotes: *"I love merch. Mostly wore the Allen House quarterzip for style."*

Theme 5: Students reported little to no knowledge of house communities before coming to Dartmouth.

The first interaction that students have with their house is through StarPortal, receiving their room assignment. Because of this introduction and the lack of information provided on the extent of house programming/resources, students enter Dartmouth with a perception of house communities as for purely residential purposes.

- Key Quotes: *"I saw house communities on StarPortal, but did not know what they were.", "I thought [house communities] were purely residential."*

Theme 6: Students reported a lack of clear communication as a reason for not participating in house programming.

The weekly newsletters, while clear and informative, are often overlooked in the mass of ListServ emails, while posters proved more effective overall. Students also seem unaware or unsure of how to get involved within their house, be that with student council or other opportunities.

- Many students reported they wanted to get involved with houses through house council, designing house merch and through other avenues of involvement in their freshmen year but simply didn't know how to pursue any of these opportunities. Besides the UGA role, many students weren't even aware of the various ways they could get involved with houses, which indicated a lack of effective advertisement.
- The Interhouse cup was repeatedly mentioned as being fun, an opportunity for low stakes play and something that would be "a big deal" as one student mentioned, but students didn't hear about the Interhouse cup much.
- Lastly, weekly newsletters were cited for being the primary way students read about house programming, though many read it two to three newsletters a term and many also just skim through it. Flyers were also effective at times to communicate programming and hearing about events through friends was another way students heard about house programming like food events and trips.
- Key Quotes: *"I thought the Interhouse Cup would be a big deal, but didn't hear anything about it.", "I don't know how to get involved with house communities besides being a UGA.", "I wanted to get involved with the logo design of West House." (the person reached out to one of the house community staff, but did not get a response back)*

Theme 7: Seniors reported an interest in reengaging with their house, taking advantage of programming in order to connect with other seniors during their final few terms at Dartmouth.

House communities are not separated by majors, interests, or backgrounds, and thus serve as a space to meet a wide variety of people.

- Key Quotes: *"For seniors, there should be coffee chats with other seniors. I studied CS, but haven't met Gov people or Econ people.", "I outgrew house events. They feel repetitive and there aren't many seniors.", "I would love to go to senior-only events to get to know more classmates."*

Theme 8: Students expressed interest in recurring events, scheduled at the same time during the week throughout the term.

Establishing a routine of programming would allow students to foster friendships formed at prior events, offering an avenue for continued connection and tradition within their house.

- Key Quotes: *"Making events repetitive would help to build connection and a sense of tradition."*

Theme 9: Students are hesitant to go to themed dinners because of themes.

Open, non-specific events are important to encourage students to engage with their house community–any barrier to entry can drive away student engagement.

- Key Quotes: *"I hesitate to go to dinners because of the theme", "Don't combine themes with dinners"*

Theme 10: The presence of natural lighting, a variety of seating options, free coffee/tea/snacks, and the presence of other students determine how much a space is used by students.

- Students repeatedly sighted the presence of natural lighting as one of the factors that attracted them to study spaces like libraries, their room, common rooms etc.
- Students also like to switch different seating based on their mood. For example, they would sit on a bean bag if they were casually working or spending time with friends, and a desk and a chair if they were studying. Brace commons and Cube were particularly sighted as "good" because of the variety of seating options.
- There was a liking for studying in silence, but students did prefer to study at places where they could take a quick break and talk to some friends/acquaintances. In other words, they wanted other people near where they were studying. For this reason, the library was sighted as the most commonly used space for studying and Novak particularly served as a break spot where students could socialize and talk to their friends/acquaintances. Cube similarly was liked for the same reason.
- Another repeated need from students was free snacks and coffee/tea/snacks in common spaces. Indeed, one of the reasons why spaces like One Wheelock and Magnuson Center for Entrepreneurship are frequently used as study spaces is because of the presence of free coffee machines.
- Additionally, students directly mentioned the liking/desire for having following items in house spaces:
    1. White boards
    2. Free stationary (pencils, pens, pencil sharpeners)
    3. Phone/Laptop chargers
    4. Board games
    5. Warm lighting

- Key Quotes: *"People want people", "People are drawn to social/busy spaces", "The reason I like East Wheelock is because all buildings are connected to Brace and people can interact", "Give spaces a warm/old feeling–HYGGE", "People are drawn to cozier spaces like One Wheelock"*

Theme 11: Events where bonding and socialization occurs naturally or organically are more successful.

- Low energy, activity-based events (like crafting or cooking) make it easier for students to meet new people. People don't want to be forced to participate in events.
- One of the interviewees recounted going to an event for food, but had to wait 30 minutes and meditate until they started serving food. "I like to practice mindfulness but on my own," they commented. "I would like just free dinner and no catch like mindfulness," they added.
- Key Quotes: *"Make events more organic, like Sanborn tea", "I like the crafting events because I can do my activity and also talk to new people"*

Theme 12: Students prefer lower time commitment on-campus events and trips arranged by houses.

- Students like to attend events hosted by houses during the time in between classes, meetings and other social commitments. Therefore, there is higher preference for keeping the events short (0.5 - 1 hour long). An interviewee noted, "I don't want to spend more than an hour on a small event."
- Trips that take place off campus are preferred when they don't take up an entire day. Ski trips were repeatedly quoted as being desirable. While overnight trips such as NYC or Portland do attract student interest, we found that the larger commitment takes away from widespread involvement.

Theme 13: Community dinners by houses are very popular among students.

- Many students reported to have attended house community dinners and wanted an increase in their frequency per term. Students reported free food as the primary driver for attraction but also mentioned having met new students, undergrad, grad and study abroad students, since "you can sit on a random table with other students." Another student mentioned, "I have met German exchange students and other people at community dinners."
- The popularity surrounding community dinners offers an opportunity for a stronger house tradition to form around them.

Theme 14: By offering life skill workshops, particularly to seniors, Houses can fill a niche currently untapped by Greek Life or other organizations.

- Houses could offer life skill workshops, where students can navigate their transition to adulthood and learn tangible skills. Examples include personal finance lessons, cooking classes, grocery shopping trips, driving lessons
- Key Quotes: *"I would really benefit from learning these personal skills, and that is something that is currently not done by many other large campus groups."*

Theme 15: Students prefer event locations that are near their residential buildings.

- Key Quotes: *"Didn't go to a lot of events in Brace because it is far away and I'm busy.", "If there is a community at my dorm, I would go socialize with them. I don't need to go to onion to socialize"*

Theme 16: Students' connections with ADs, PAs, and the House Professor varied; many didn't know who they were, but those who did found them welcoming and supportive.

- Key Quotes: *"Allen House AD first person to lend a hand", "During orientation, I went to house Professor's home and felt a sense of community", "Bonghee is the reason I felt welcomed in east wheelock because she smiled whenever she saw me", "good to be taken care of by house professor who cares"*

Recommendations

1. How might we make students identify more with their house community?

Short-term recommendations (0-2 years)

Recommendation 1: Establish an art gallery in an underutilized common room, rotating student work (paintings, textile art, and other visual media) each term.

- *Why:* A display of personal work creates a sense of appreciation, belonging and honor within a community which would help foster a stronger connection of the students displaying their work with their houses.
- *What's needed:* Room for art display, student application, review committee, maintenance staff

Recommendation 2: Each spring, freshman cohorts could paint a large-scale version of their house logo together (a tradition modeled on the sophomore pong table painting in Greek spaces). Recent paintings displayed in high-traffic spaces, others in residential buildings

- *Why:* This creates a group activity where students can feel connected with one another in a house and feel ownership in the house by seeing their painting and a sense of history by seeing past years' paintings. Over time, this builds a visible, evolving record of each house's history.
- *What's needed:* Planning by houses.

Recommendation 3: Display a composite photograph of all current and alumni house members in a central common space such as Cube for Allen House.

- *Why:* Seeing your own picture makes you feel like you are seen, which is an integral part of being in a good community, and showing alumni pictures creates house history which would be powerful in creating house history.
- *What's needed:* Budget and design for composites. Not sure about decisions.

Long-term recommendations (2+ years)

Recommendation 1: Launch a donations campaign for houses and display a picture or artifact recognizing donors in residential buildings and common rooms.

- *Why:* This creates transparency and initiative within houses, increasing their perceived importance among students.
- *What's needed:* A person or a committee who can lead the donation campaign. Designing, building and installing the artifact.

Recommendation 2: Convert underutilized common rooms in house buildings into shared spaces (snack bars, cafes, late-night spots, sewing rooms, music rooms) and hire students from within the house to staff them.

- *Why:* This recommendation reflects how Yale gives students ownership over various aspects of their residential colleges, especially over their late night “buttery” cafes. These opportunities allow students to take on leadership roles, develop a personal stake in their college, and create a student space where members can socialize and get to know one another.
- *What's needed:* Underutilized common rooms, equipment for specific use case, student staff to run it and House staff to support the student staff

Recommendation 3: Use under-utilized common rooms to add pool tables, foosball tables, and other games to encourage organic interactions.

- *Why:* This addition would further social interaction within residential buildings and inter-house connection outside of specific programming events.
- *What's needed:* Budget for buying these tables, location where they should be placed and someone to oversee installment and maintenance

Recommendation 4: Partner up with Yale and other Ivies for an inter-college house sport tournament.

- *Why:* Interaction with other schools would heighten the stakes of the tournament and increase overall engagement with house sports.
- *What's needed:* Conversations with Yale and other peer institutions

Recommendation 5: Allow a selected number of approved non-UGA students to apply for funding to host an event within their house.

- *Why:* Presents an opportunity for students to directly influence their house, and take ownership of the communal space.
- *What's needed:* Budget, application, committee who approves the program request, and House Program Administrator's help in arranging the event

Recommendation 6: Yearly house awards (with ceremony) for students to recognize community builders within the house.

- *Why:* Awards would add an element of prestige to house involvement, as well as incentive individual student engagement.
- *What's needed:* Brainstorming various recognition awards, designing physical awards, event planning

2. How might we create a sustained engagement with houses by freshmen after freshman fall

<u>Short-term recommendations (0-2 years)</u>

Recommendation 1: International student O-week groups are building specific

- *Why:* Repeated interactions with people within the building create opportunities for deeper, lasting friendships within the building and the broader house community.
- *What's needed:* Not sure.

Recommendation 2: Host more building-wide events instead of floor-specific events.

- *Why:* This would increase overall event attendance and help to unite students within a subsection of their house community.
- *What's needed:* Switching budget from floor events to building events

Recommendation 3: UGAs attend first-year trips with freshmen.

- *Why:* Increases bonding and connection between students on a floor and their UGAs.
- *What's needed:* Adding this as one of the responsibilities of first year UGAs.

Recommendation 4: Have “college husband” or “college wife” for freshman students for emotional support across buildings within a house (similar to Keble College at Oxford)

- *Why:* This could be a quirky house tradition. Students uncomfortable with such an idea could opt out, but this would generally give students a unique way of interacting with other students in their houses.
- *What's needed:* Logistics planning

3. How might we allow seniors to meet other seniors during senior year?

<u>Short-term recommendations (0-2 years)</u>

Recommendation 1: Create a coffee chat program where seniors get randomly paired up with other seniors based on a survey (coffee chats paid for by college).

- *Why:* Seniors want to meet other seniors and house can provide that opportunity
- *What's needed:* Extra budget, survey questions planning

Recommendation 2: Host Microbrews or similar events at the Cube to both engage seniors and promote that house space.

- *Why:* Good way to engage seniors who are grown up young adults
- *What's needed*: Budget

Recommendation 3: Host senior trips (like FYT) within houses during the start of senior fall.

- *Why:* Nostalgia around First Year Trips and the willingness to meet new people in senior year would get seniors interested in this and as a result, there could be be reunion with their houses
- *What's needed:* Extra budget, a lot of planning, and this planning could be given to students in the houses themselves

<u>Long-term recommendations (2+ years)</u>

Recommendation 1: Establish workshops for seniors (personal finance lessons, cooking classes, grocery shopping, driving lessons)

- *Why:* In the interviews, a lot of seniors expressed interest in learning day-to-day skills, quoting above skills in parentheses,
- *What's needed:* Extra budget, planning the workshops. Seniors who want to lead these workshops may have that option. For example, a senior could give a driving lesson.

4. How might we use merch to create a sense of belonging for students in their houses?

<u>Short-term recommendations (0-2 years)</u>

Recommendation 1: Create limited edition merch that highlights important termly or yearly events.

- *Why:* This would reinforce prominent house events and frame those events into traditions.
- *What's needed:* Student designers

Recommendation 2: Make house merch more colorful and artistic, allowing students to bring their art and design into the merch (less reliant on house colors).

- *Why:* This could bring quirkyness to house identity by allowing students to bring their artistic creativity to the merch and also create a sense of ownership from designers' perspective
- *What's needed:* Student designers

<u>Long-term recommendations (2+ years)</u>

Recommendation 1: Create a merch shop where students can purchase house merch (creates a sense of value).

- *Why:* Buying merch creates a sense of value for merch and broader house identity
- *What's needed:* a physical location, and a person to oversee the shop

Recommendation 2: Display progress of merch (showing merch from previous years) in house spaces (Cube, Onion) to narrate house history.

- *Why:* Narrates house history to signal importance of house identity
- *What's needed:* Figuring out where exactly this exhibition would be held

Recommendation 2: Establish two to three merch items that stay the same over the years.

- *Why:* Taking Dartmouth Co-op's merch model where there are certain merch items that have been selling for years creating continuity within merch and the desire to own those items when seeing someone else wearing those items
- *What's needed:* Designer who could design a timeless piece of merch

5. How might we prevent the perception of house communities being non-existent or simply a place to live among freshmen?

<u>Short-term recommendations (0-2 years)</u>

Recommendation 1: Add a link to each house website on StarPortal next to dorm assignments.

- *Why:* Shifts student focus from “room assignment” to “community involvement.”
- *What's needed:* Not sure.

Recommendation 2: Standardize house websites to include specific “how-to” guides for different types of involvement.

- *Why:* Bridges the information gap for students who want to join but don’t know the entry points.
- *What's needed:* House website redesign if they don't already hold this information.

Recommendation 3: House leadership welcome email in summer

- *Why:* Establishes human connection and formalizes house’s role before students arrive.
- *What's needed:* An email by house professor.

Recommendation 4: Host house-specific virtual sessions where upperclassmen answer

incoming freshman's questions about houses.

- *Why:* Helps freshmen visualize daily student life and house community culture
- *What's needed:* A virtual session arranged by houses for incoming students

Recommendation 5: Distribute Dartmouth IDs at residential house hubs rather than a central campus location.

- *Why:* Ensures the first campus interaction is physically centered within their house.
- *What's needed:* Not sure.

Recommendation 6: House-branded campus maps (buildings labeled by house)

- *Why:* Visually reinforces house identity and territorial presence on campus.
- *What's needed:* Dartmouth map redesign, administration approval

<u>Long-term recommendations (2+ years)</u>

Recommendation 1: Allow incoming students to rank their house preferences during the summer housing application.

- *Why:* Increases student "buy-in" and perceived value through psychology of choice.
- *What's needed:* This needs to be more thought out, and therefore is under 2+ years

6. How might we improve communication and increase house engagement opportunities visibility?

<u>Short-term recommendations (0-2 years)</u>

Recommendation 1: Opt-in SMS House event alerts

- *Why:* Provides a direct, high-visibility alternative to easily ignored newsletters and flyers.
- *What's needed:* A person in each house who could curate the daily events message

Recommendation 2: Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Audit

- *Why:* Prevents students from getting lost in generic university pages and directs them to house-specific engagement details.
- *What's needed:* ITC department to improve the SEO

7. How might we create a sense of routine and an avenue for continued engagement for students?

<u>Short-term recommendations (0-2 years)</u>

Recommendation 1: Weekly fireside chats at House Professors' residences.

- Why: Facilitates repeated, low-stakes interaction that builds deep social bonds between students and faculty.
- What's needed: House Professors's availability, and food budget

Recommendation 2: Termly community dinner series with formal "End-of-Term" dinner

- *Why:* Meets student demand for graduate and undergraduate student connection and mirror prestige of other campus organizations' formals.
- *What's needed:* Reallocation of budget and planning towards these formals.

Recommendation 3: Recurring coffee and tea service (similar to Sanborn Tea)

- *Why:* Creates a predictable "third space" routine where staff and students can interact organically in a relaxed setting.
- *What's needed:* Budget allocation and planning

8. How might we create a more cozy, inviting atmosphere at house common spaces?

<u>Short-term recommendations (0-2 years)</u>

Recommendation 1: Amenities upgrade (whiteboards, coffee/snack stations, stationary supplies, chargers, board games)

- *Why:* Directly address most frequently requested items from interviews to increase space utility.
- *What's needed:* Budget reallocation and designated supply manager

Recommendation 2: Student-staffed "House Hubs" (desk jobs, manage space and supplies)

- *Why:* Provides high-demand campus jobs while making house spaces feel more personal and supervised.
- *What's needed:* Payroll budget, oversight could be integrated into UGA role

Recommendation 3: Student art gallery initiative, feature rotating display in common spaces

- *Why:* Personalizes the environment and fosters a "student-centric" identity similar to successful models at peer institutions (i.e. Yale)
- *What's needed:* Student review committee, logistics lead for installation

Recommendation 4: Place more carpet or rugs to make the space inviting.

- Why: Immediately improves acoustic comfort, creates cozy residential atmosphere
- What's needed: Investment in carpets

Recommendation 5: House therapy dog in common spaces

- *Why:* Proven to drive student attendance and reduce stress; serves as a unique community anchor
- *What's needed:* Therapy-certified dogs, caretaking rotation amongst staff and students

<u>Long-term recommendations (2+ years)</u>

Recommendation 1: Establish satellite wellness suites

- *Why:* Converting underutilized residential rooms into wellness spaces decentralizes wellness resources, making mental health support more accessible within the living community
- *What's needed:* Equipment procurement and space-use audits

Recommendation 2: Increase use of natural wood in house spaces (walls and furniture)

- *Why:* Utilizes "warm" materials to create a grounded, inviting aesthetic
- *What's needed:* Long-term renovation planning and interior design consulting

Recommendation 3: Increase warm and natural lighting in house spaces

- *Why:* Aligns with student preferences for study-conducive environments and improves overall mood
- *What's needed:* Electrical upgrades and adjustments for new and existing buildings

Recommendation 4: Increase variety of seating options within house spaces.

- Why: Allows students to choose seating that fits their specific mood or task, increasing long term comfort and making house spaces multifunctional
- What's needed: Gradual replacement of standardized furniture with varied options

Miscellaneous Recommendations

<u>Short-term recommendations (0-2 years)</u>

Recommendation 1: Increase the number of crafting events (painting, mug making, sewing, etc.) and possibly partner with the Hop for other artistic events.

- Why: students find it easy to do an activity and socialize with other students which makes the interactions less awkward and natural
- What's needed: Reallocation of house event budget

Recommendation 2: On-campus house events (floor, building, and house-wide events) should be at the maximum 1 hour long and house trips (off-campus) so that students can return within half a day and get back to work

- Why: Students come to on-campus house events during the free time between classes and extracurriculars and as a result don't want to spend more than 1 hour on any event. Similarly, the longer trips that take up entire day or overnight trips are usually too much of a time commitment amidst the busy schedule
- What's needed: Self-explanatory

<u>Long-term recommendations (2+ years)</u>

Recommendation 1: Add more house communities based on proximity of building with one another. For example, instead of South House including Fayerweathers and New Hamp, Topliff and Lodge, making Fayerweathers a separate House Community and New Hamp, Topliff and Lodge a separate House Community. Currently, West House and South House buildings feel very dispersed and disconnected for students

- *Why:* This is based on the insight how important proximity to other buildings is in allowing students to socialize with students living in other buildings and how close students feel within their building. Smaller house community with increased proximity to to other house buildings and dedicated house staff would increase the tight-knitness of these smaller house communities
- *What's needed:* Understanding long term residential building plans and considering the proximity of residential buildings with other residential buildings.

Recommendation 2: Each house should have a mini library of its own

- *Why:* Library attracts students to study and this currently happens at the baker-berry library. To form close house ties, students need to spend more time within their house space and a mini library could be one of these spaces.
- *What's needed:* Construction of mini libraries near current house buildings

Recommendation 3: Open a new house staff position that works closely with the House

professor to arrange more intellectual events

- Why: From our fall term research, Program Administrators and Assistant Directors feel very over-worked and many students report not seeing house professors enough at events. This new position could relieve some burden of intellectual program management from Program Administrator and Assistant Director, and allow House professors to plan more intellectual programming fulfilling intellectual engagement goal of house communities

Additional Information

- There is a need for assessing the UGA and RF role, which oftentimes is cited as not fully fleshed out by House ADs, Program Administrators and House professors in Rohan's conversations with these various people. This assessment should include what different kinds of UGAs there should be, how should their roles differ, how different should their training be.
- Similar evaluation for House Professor, Assistant Director and Program Administrator should occur to fully define their roles and specific responsibilities and how much additional support they need, if any.
- The recommendations we provided would only be properly implemented if fully thought out by house staff. Unless we clearly define the house staff roles and how much additional support they need in incorporating these recommendations besides their current work, all efforts to improve houses would be in vain.
- The scope of the research wasn't fully defined in 25F, which is why we ended up conducting interviews with a House Program Administrator and Assistant Director. In 26W, we focused primarily on getting a student perspective. Regardless, the interview notes with House Program Administrator and an Assistant Director are attached in Appendix F.

Appendices

Appendix A: Research Scope
Research Scope

Appendix B: Student Interviews
Student interviewee demographics
Student interview questions
Revised interview questions
Student interview notes

Appendix C: Research & Synthesis
Research & synthesis process document
Themes synthesis from interviews
Recommendations brainstorming

Appendix D: Yale Trip Pictures
Yale trip pictures

Appendix E: House Sub-Committee Presentations
26W Midterm report
25F Definition of Community
Staff/Student Perspective

Appendix F: House Staff Interviews
Assistant Director Interview Notes
Program Administrator interview notes